



The Sonoran Desert

One of the wettest deserts on Earth, with an abundance of plant species

A place of transition between temperate and tropical climates, the Sonoran Desert merges into the Chihuahuan Desert to the southeast and the Mojave to the northwest. Calderas bear witness to the prehistoric volcanic eruptions that created the desert's mountain ranges, valleys, and alluvial fans known as *bajadas*. The Sonoran's annual rainfall of 3–20 in (7–50 cm)—the most in any North American desert—supports over 2,000 plant species. These must survive average summer temperatures of 104°F (40°C), but winters are relatively mild at 50°F (10°C), with few frosts.

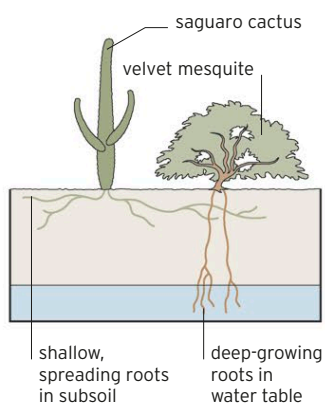
▽ DESERT IN BLOOM

Winter rains transform the Sonoran with patches of color, as plants such as dune evening primrose and pink sand verbena bloom in profusion.



ROOT NETWORKS

Sonoran plants use varied strategies to survive drought conditions. Within hours of rainfall, saguaro cacti send out new roots close to the surface to store water in their expanding stems. Velvet mesquite roots burrow 165 ft (50 m) downward to tap into the water table.



▽ HANDS UP

The valley's distinctive West and East Mitten Buttes have intrigued visitors for decades. Viewed from the south, they resemble two giant mittens, held thumbs-upward.

